technologies. As one UP district vice president told me, ‘after Corona happened’, the party could switch to ‘virtual meetings’ on such a large scale only because it had the ‘full database ready’. By 2020, in UP’s districts, he said in each of the 300 polling booths in his Vidhan Sabha constituency, the party had multiple lists of: five people with motorcycles, five with smartphones, five influential people, five who could provide funds. ‘Such lists are ready at the booth level,’ he said. ‘These lists are over and above the lists of our office-bearers and their committees at these booths. This work is happening because of that policy’ of depth of organisation.

Panna Pramukhs and Vistaraks: An Idea from Gujarat

The BJP’s booth-level mobilisation is driven deeper during election periods by two new local entities that are largely active only during the campaign season: panna pramukh (page head/in-charge) and vistaraks (expanders).

A panna pramukh is essentially in charge of a single page (panna) of the voting list in their area’s voting booth. To understand how this works in practice, let us zoom in on Karnataka. As Ravi Kumar explained, ‘A very important part is played by the panna pramukh for the party. There are thirty-two pages in a booth-level voter list in Karnataka. So, thirty-two panna pramukhs will be there for a voting booth, one for each page. Their job is to go to five-six houses, whose members are listed on that page, and to connect with them at least a couple of times in a year, election or no election, so 100 per cent connect is there for the party.’[56]

Of course, appointing last-mile workers like panna pramukhs is one thing; getting them to win over voters is another. The idea is to essentially build a network of local relationships. Yet, it has obvious operational pitfalls as well. ‘Basically, it has its own strength and its limitations,’ says BJP’s Vinay Sahasrabuddhe, who as party vice president was co-in-charge of the BJP’s membership expansion campaign. He explained what the party expects from its page in-charges and how they are supposed to build local relationships:[57]